

Four Hundred

There is a part of the work I look forward to all week, and it is not the part anyone would film.

By the time I reach it the guitar has already been ugly. That comes first, and it has to. You take a body somebody else finished wrong, or that you finished wrong yourself, and you start with the coarse paper, and for a while the thing looks worse than when you started. Bare wood does not flatter anybody. It shows the gouges. It shows where the grain ran out. There is no hiding on a piece stripped down to nothing, which is exactly why I stopped being afraid of that stage. It is the most honest the wood ever looks, and the beginning of the repair, not the end of it.

Then you climb. One twenty first, still coarse enough to feel the bite through your fingers. Then two twenty, which most people would call smooth and isn't, not yet. You can still catch the small ridges if you know to look, and the work at that stage is patient and unglamorous and nobody's idea of progress. You are just removing what the last paper left behind, and then removing what this one leaves, on up the line.

Four hundred is my favorite, and I have thought about why. By four hundred the walnut is already bare. It is already smooth. A man who didn't know better would have stopped two papers ago and called it done. But you run the four hundred over it and the surface keeps getting better under your hand, noticeably better, even though nothing was obviously wrong with it before you started. And this is where the chatoyance comes up.

There is no plain English word for it, so the old woodworkers borrowed the French one, from the word for a cat's eye, the shimmer that seems to live inside a thing instead of on top of it. It works like this. The grain in a good piece of walnut does not run flat and straight the way you'd draw it. It rises and dives in waves down through the board. So when light comes across a smooth-enough surface, the fibers tipped toward the light go bright and the fibers tipped away go dark, and the wood looks lit from somewhere underneath, as if you could put your hand down into it. Tilt the body a few degrees under the shop light and the bright and dark trade places, and the figure rolls, a slow band of light sliding across the wood and settling back when you hold it still.

It is not there at one twenty. It is not there at two twenty. The figure was in the walnut the whole time, the whole life of the tree, but a rough surface scatters the light off its scratches and hands you back a flat brown nothing. Then somewhere in the four hundred the scratches get fine enough that the light stops bouncing off the top and starts going down into the grain, and the body comes alive in your hands. Warm and slow, the browns going to honey and then to something near black in the deep of the figure, all of it moving as you turn it. You did not put that there. You took the piece down to bare and then had the patience to work past smooth, past the point anyone standing in the doorway would fault you for stopping, until the surface was finally ready to let the light all the way in.

I learned what that was worth years before I could use it, from Audley Freed on that picnic table in Denver, the afternoon I have already told you about, when I watched him play to no one an hour before the gates opened and could not yet say what I was looking at. I can say it now. He was at four hundred grit. Now I have an afternoon, a body clamped on the bench, no one watching, and I run the four hundred over bare walnut and feel the surface come up under my fingers, and the want to be seen doing it has gone quiet enough that some days I forget it was ever the loudest thing in me.

And then the oil. Birchwood Casey Tru-Oil, the same finish men have rubbed into gunstocks for a hundred years, which is right, because it was made for things meant to be carried and used and handed down, not things meant to sit behind glass. The first coat goes on and the walnut you spent all that time preparing just opens. The figure you raised at four hundred deepens, the browns going darker and warmer at once, the chatoyance you found under the dry paper now wet with oil and twice as alive, lit from down inside the grain. The deep of the figure goes near black, and where the light catches the rise of it you get a streak of red-brown, of old leather, of something with years in it though the guitar is new. Each coat does it again. You think it cannot get richer and it does. Thin coats, cut back between them, more patience, and the body turns gorgeous in your hands one layer at a time, and the gorgeous is not laid on top. It was down in the walnut the whole time. You took everything off of it and then had the patience not to stop at smooth.

I gouged mine more times than I want to count. I know what the coarse paper is for from the inside. But I am at the bench now, most days, and most days I make it to four hundred, and the oil still does what it does, every single time, and never once warns me it is about to be this good.